

Jio joins India's big Esports push

The 2026 edition of India Rising will debut with Chess as its **flagship** title — a natural choice given India's status as a powerhouse in the game, owing to its success in recent years.

Neeladri Bhattacharjee
neeladri.b@thehindu.co.in

For years, Indian gamers have populated streams, packed stadiums, and hosted viewing parties, making the country one of the world's fastest-growing gaming markets. And to ride onto the wave of rising popularity, Reliance, one of India's biggest conglomerates, has moved into a new project, with the Esports World Cup in mind.

The Esports World Cup Foundation (EWCF) and JioBLAST — a joint venture of Reliance-owned Jio and top-tier esports tournament organiser, BLAST — have announced a strategic partnership to launch India Rising: Road to EWC, a national competition pathway and festival designed to connect grassroots Indian talent directly to the Esports World Cup (EWC).

"India has the second biggest gaming base and one of the most passionate gaming communities in the world, but what has been missing is a clear and credible pathway from India into the biggest global stages. Partnering with the Esports World Cup to build India Rising: Road to EWC will change that," Charlie Cowdrey, CEO, JioBLAST, said.

The 2026 edition of India Rising will debut with Chess as its flagship title — a natural choice given India's status as a powerhouse in the game, owing to its success in recent years. Arjun Erigaisi (**in pic**) and Nihal Sarin, have already participated at EWC 2025.

The new project aims to rope in the players who are relatively unknown, from the grassroots.

All titled Indian players will receive invites to closed qualifiers, while open registration is expected to draw more than 10,000 grassroots competitors. The winner will advance directly to the EWC 2026 Chess main event in

Riyadh (August 11–15), joining a 21-player field competing for a USD 1.5 million (~INR 14.46 cr) prize pool.

But the vision extends beyond the 64 squares. The initiative will culminate in an offline festival in Mumbai, where fans can watch the Chess finals live alongside exhibition matches in VALORANT and Moba Legends: 5v5.

"The Esports World Cup's purpose is to unite the global gaming community, and that means investing in regions shaping the future of the industry. India is central to that vision," said Mohammed Al Nimer, Chief Commercial Officer of the Esports Foundation.

S8UL QUALIFIES FOR HONOR OF KINGS WORLD CUP

S8UL qualified for the Honor of Kings World Cup (KWC) at the EWC 2026 after a commanding run at the King's Arise India Qualifier. It will now compete with 20 of the world's top teams for the title and a prize pool of USD 3 million (~INR 28.5 crore) from July 30 to August 8.

The lineup featuring Indian players Saad Sardar (Darkness), Hayrambh Monga (Meruem), Prabhat Mahato (Xtreme), Vishnu Khatri (Xesol), Rahul Lavhate (Kyurem), and new addition Saurabh Jagadale (Kael), alongside Nepal's Suyog Paudel (Doofy) and China's Ang Xin Hao (Kong), entered the playoffs after winning the Kings' Arise City Tour - Mumbai.

The team began its playoff campaign with a 4-2 victory over Resurrection Imp. in the quarterfinals before defeating GodLike Esports 4-1 in the best-of-seven semifinals to secure qualification for KWC 2026, as the top two teams from the event advanced to the global tournament.